DAY 20 | HANDS-ON ACTIVITIES

FDE Professional Skills 2: Simulation and Role Play Cards

Scenario cards for today's simulations and role plays. Facilitators: read the scenario aloud, set a timer, then debrief.

Prepared by **Ahmed** | linkedin.com/in/ahmed-al-imaad

How to work: read the whole card first. Agree roles. Stay in character until time is up. In the debrief, share one thing that worked and one thing to try next time.

Activity 1: The Dashboard Is Slow

Format: Simulation with data, teams of 3, 60 minutes | **Skills:** problem framing, hypotheses, evidence

The customer's operations lead says: "Your dashboard is slow and my team is losing patience." Use today's notebook with the request logs. Write a problem statement, build an issue tree, test at least three hypotheses with the data, and prepare a two-minute readout.

What good looks like

Problem statement with who, what, impact and a success measure
At least three hypotheses, each marked confirmed or rejected with a number
A clear finding, for example the slowest endpoint, tenant and time window
A small, specific next step with an owner

Tips

- Do not jump to "we need a bigger server".
- Let the data surprise you.
- Lead the readout with the answer.

Activity 2: Five Whys

Format: Pairs, 15 minutes | **Skills:** root cause analysis

Problem: "The weekly sales report was wrong three times this quarter." One person plays the data analyst who knows the history; the other asks why, five times. Swap with: "New users keep calling support about login."

What good looks like

Why 1: numbers were wrong. Why 2: the job ran on partial data. Why 3: the upstream file arrived late. Why 4: no check for file completeness. Why 5: the pipeline was built without data quality checks.
Action: add a completeness check before the report runs

Tips

- Stop when the answer is something you can change.
- Avoid blaming people; look for missing processes.

Activity 3: Stakeholder Interviews

Format: Role play, rotating, 4 rounds of 8 minutes | **Skills:** discovery, empathy, synthesis

Four role cards: the sponsor (wants a faster quarter-end close), a daily user (spends hours fixing spreadsheet errors), IT (worried about a fragile legacy database), and security (no customer data may leave the private network). Interview each, then write one paragraph combining what you learned.

What good looks like

Open questions and "show me" requests
Each stakeholder's main concern written in their words
A combined problem statement that respects the security constraint
One conflict between stakeholders identified and a question to resolve it

Tips

- Ask about the last time it happened.
- Summarise back before moving on.

Activity 4: The Scope Request

Format: Role play, pairs, 2 rounds of 8 minutes | **Skills:** scope management, trade-offs, trust

Two weeks into a four-week MVP, the sponsor asks: "Can you also add a mobile version and connect it to our CRM? The board meets next month." The MVP is on track but has no spare capacity.

What good looks like

Acknowledge the goal behind the request (impressing the board)
Show the current plan and what would move
Offer options: a CRM export instead of an integration, mobile-friendly layout instead of an app
Agree a decision and write it down

Tips

- "Yes, and here is what moves" beats "no".
- Ask what the board needs to see.

Activity 5: Readout to the Sponsor

Format: Team presentation, 3 minutes each | **Skills:** executive communication

Present the findings from activity 1 to the sponsor (played by the facilitator). The sponsor will interrupt with one tough question.

What good looks like

Answer first in one sentence
Two or three pieces of evidence with numbers
Recommendation and next step with owner and date
Calm, honest answer to the tough question, including "I do not know yet, I will find out by Tuesday" if needed

Tips

- Practise the first sentence out loud.
- Use the chart from the notebook.

Activity 6: Handover Note

Format: Individual writing, 15 minutes | **Skills:** documentation, ownership

Write a handover note for the dashboard work so a customer engineer could continue after you leave.

What good looks like

Context, what was found, what was changed, how to check it is working, known risks, and who to contact
Under 250 words

Tips

- Write for someone who was not in the room.
- Link to the decision log.

Naze naze bunseki (なぜなぜ分析): why-why analysis